

Weddings, Marriage Blessings, and Renewals of Vows

AT WASHINGTON NATIONAL CATHEDRAL



DEAR FRIENDS IN CHRIST,

A marriage is one of the most joyful services celebrated in churches. Holy Matrimony is defined as a Christian marriage in which two adults enter a lifelong union, make their vows before God and the Church, and receive God's grace and blessing to help them to fulfill their vows. It is a covenant of love.

These guidelines are intended to assist with planning a wedding, marriage blessing, or renewal of vows at Washington National Cathedral. The Cathedral, by its mission, is a house of prayer for all people, a great church for national purposes, and the cathedral of the Episcopal Diocese of Washington. While warmly welcoming all, the customs and practices of our ministries follow the procedures and rituals of The Episcopal Church and the Episcopal Diocese of Washington.

Kindly review the information provided and feel free to call on the Cathedral's worship department for further guidance as you plan for a service.



The Reverend Canon Rosemarie Logan Duncan
Canon for Worship

Set me as a seal upon your heart, as a seal upon your arm,
for love is strong as death, jealousy is fierce as the grave.
Its flashes are flashes of fire, the very flame of the Lord.
Many waters cannot quench love, neither can floods drown it.

— SONG OF SOLOMON 8:6



INTRODUCTION

The solemnization of a marriage—a wedding—is an expression of the Christian community and draws on the common metaphor for humankind's relationship with God. The covenant of marriage was established by God in creation. The Old Testament prophet Isaiah speaks of the relationship of God to Israel in exile using the metaphor of a husband returning in compassion to an abandoned wife. Throughout the Bible, the garments of salvation are described as being like wedding attire. The Gospel of Matthew describes the kingdom of heaven as a wedding feast. Indeed, Jesus performed the first miracle at a wedding in Cana of Galilee.

So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let no one separate.

— MATTHEW 19:6

GENERAL GUIDELINES AND CONSIDERATIONS

Weddings at Washington National Cathedral, known formally as the Cathedral Church of Saint Peter and Saint Paul, are offered in accordance with the following:

- Adherence to the canons and practices of The Episcopal Church and the pastoral directives of the bishop of the Episcopal Diocese of Washington.
- At least one member of the couple must be a baptized Christian.
- The discretion of the dean of the Cathedral.
- The availability of time, essential support staff, and space on the Cathedral calendar.
- Such a service is appropriate to the values and mission of the Cathedral.



ABOUT WEDDINGS

As an expression of Christian community, weddings held at the Cathedral follow the form of the Book of Common Prayer (page 423). Cathedral weddings may also use other liturgies authorized by The Episcopal Church: The Witnessing and Blessing of a Marriage and The Celebration and Blessing of a Marriage 2. These two resources are most often used for more modern weddings, relationship blessings (vow renewals), and same-sex weddings. In addition, marriage liturgies from A New Zealand Prayer Book, He Karakia Mihinare o Aotearoa have also been approved by the bishop of the Episcopal Diocese of Washington.

The Cathedral maintains its integrity as an Episcopal church while respecting the religious customs and practices of others. Within the structure of these authorized rites, many options are offered, such as selections of readings, music, and prayers, to reflect the traditions of the couple and/or their family members.

The Cathedral worship department reserves the final decision regarding all liturgies at Washington National Cathedral.

REQUIREMENTS

The following is required for the solemnization of marriage in The Episcopal Church:

- Where it is determined that: (a) that both parties have the right to marry according to the laws of the state and consent to do so freely, without fraud, coercion, mistake as to the identity of either, or mental reservation; (b) that at least one of the parties is a baptized Christian (documentation of baptism required); and (c) that both parties have been instructed by the clergy or a licensed professional counselor (licensed clinical social worker, psychologist or mental health specialist), in the nature, purpose, and meaning, as well as the rights, duties, and responsibilities of marriage.
- That the couple notify the member of clergy of the intent to marry at least thirty days prior to the solemnization date. If for weighty cause, a shorter amount of time is needed, it can be waived by the member of the clergy, in consultation with the bishop of the Episcopal Diocese of Washington.
- Only liturgical forms found in the Book of Common Prayer and those otherwise authorized.
- That prior to the solemnization, the parties shall sign the Declaration of Intention.
- That at least two witnesses shall be present at the solemnization, and together with the clergy and the parties, sign the record of the solemnization in the Cathedral register; which record shall include the date and place of the solemnization, the names of the witnesses, the parties and their parents, the age of the parties, church status, and residence(s).

REMARRIAGE

The Episcopal Church believes that marriage is a lifelong commitment, but also understands that love and relationships can change in irreparable ways. If either or both parties have been divorced, the officiating clergy must request and receive permission from the bishop of the Episcopal Diocese of Washington to perform a remarriage.

If this is required, interested couples must contact the Cathedral and begin the process at least six months before they hope to be married. Couples are asked not to announce a date for their proposed marriage until the bishop's consent is given, as the wedding cannot be confirmed or performed without such consent.

> *And now these three remain: faith, hope and love. But the greatest of these is love.*
>
> — I CORINTHIANS 13:13

BLESSING OF A CIVIL MARRIAGE

The Episcopal Church provides a liturgy for the Blessing of a Civil Marriage. Couples who have chosen to be married in a civil ceremony may have their union blessed by a member of the Cathedral clergy. Please be aware that the form for the Blessing of a Civil Marriage, while similar to the marriage service, is different in its wording and intent. Please see the appendix for differences in the structure of the services.

A certified copy of the marriage certificate must be provided 30 days ahead of the service. At any time, the Cathedral reserves the right to cancel any ceremony that has been misrepresented as a marriage that is in fact a civil marriage blessing.

RENEWAL OF WEDDING VOWS

There are occasions, such as milestones of married life or the conclusion of a period of matrimonial stress with reconciliation, when couples wish to renew their wedding vows. The Episcopal Church provides a liturgy for this situation. This service provides for a renewal of vows, thanksgiving by the couple, and blessing. Such services offer an opportunity to include children, grandchildren, wider family, and friends. The standards and procedures concerning flowers, music, and fees outlined in this document also apply to renewal of wedding vows.



PLANNING YOUR SERVICE

Scheduling

Once a service is approved to be held at the Cathedral, the pastoral needs of the couple are considered paramount. In scheduling a service, the Cathedral considers the daily round of worship services, as well as the frequent programs, concerts, and school events hosted throughout the year.

Weddings at the Cathedral are typically scheduled on Saturdays. Weddings are not scheduled on Sundays. Standard Saturday hours for weddings are: 11:00 am, 4:00 pm, and 6:00 pm. Services including the Eucharist are limited to the same times as above.

Traditionally marriages are not celebrated in the seasons of Advent and Christmas (the Saturday preceding Thanksgiving Day through January 6) or in Lent, Holy Week, and Easter Week (Ash Wednesday through the Sunday after Easter Day).

Scheduling is coordinated between multiple departments of the Cathedral on behalf of the couple. To begin the process of scheduling a service, please contact Espy Crisostomo via email at ecrisostomo@cathedral.org.

Announcements concerning the details of the service may be made public only after the execution of the contract.

Planning Meeting

After a service date is confirmed, the couple participates in a planning meeting with the officiating clergy and members of the Cathedral staff to plan the service. Both members of the couple are required to attend the meeting, which is limited to the couple, participating clergy, and Cathedral staff. This meeting happens no later than three months before the wedding date. During this meeting, the couple finalizes choices regarding scriptural readings, music, and prayers. Within the structure of the prayer book rites, options are available to reflect the life and wishes of those getting married. Participants in the service are also finalized at this time.

Spaces

Weddings usually occur in Bethlehem Chapel, the Great Choir, or the nave. However, services may be scheduled in any of the chapels of the Cathedral or outside spaces as approved.



FLOWERS

Flowers are included in service fees. These arrangements are made by the Cathedral flower guild, in consultation with the couple. The flower guild may be reached at flowers@cathedral.org. Flowers, wreaths, or other decorations from outside vendors, family, or friends are generally not permitted. Consultation with the flower guild should take place no later than three months prior to the wedding.

The flower budget included in the package is sufficient for arrangements of seasonal flowers in the worship space. If elaborate arrangements or arrangements with specific colors or schemes are desired, the couple should review the fee sheet for additional details and budget accordingly. After the wedding, flowers remain in the Cathedral in thanksgiving for the marriage.

When more than one wedding is to take place in a chapel or at the high altar on a given day, the flowers will be white, unless a different color scheme is agreed upon by the couples in both weddings.

The bouquet and the wedding party's corsages and boutonnieres are to be procured from an outside florist. These flowers must be delivered to the residence of a member of the wedding party. The Cathedral is not able to accept deliveries.

MUSIC



The Cathedral enjoys a rich tradition of musical excellence. Music selections for all weddings are made by the couple in collaboration with the worship and music departments. Any request for choral or other instrumental music must be made to and approved by the organist and/or director of music. Please bear in mind that a wedding is a worship service and, therefore, only sacred music is permitted. In the selection of all music, attention is called to the rubrics on page 14 of the prayer book, which require that vocal music be from Holy Scripture, the prayer book, or texts congruent with them.

The music department is responsible for all Cathedral musicians and the invitation of all visiting musicians. No musical arrangements may be made without the music department's prior approval.

Arrangements for additional musical support such as vocalists, carillon, peal bells, and choirs can be arranged at extra costs and based on availability.

All music should be chosen no later than three months before the scheduled service.

PRINTED PROGRAM (LEAFLETS)

The worship department produces a printed order of service (leaflet) for all wedding services Sample service leaflets are available. Where possible, with regards to space, all texts of the service are included. All texts must be in the public domain or from copyrighted sources that expressly permit limited reproduction. If couple wishes to include text from other sources, it is their responsibility to secure and provide the necessary usage permissions. Space permitting, a brief message from the couple may be included. All content for the wedding must be confirmed no later than three months before the wedding. Production charges may be higher if the service bulletin content is not submitted in a timely fashion or additional pages or inserts are requested.

All orders of service carry the following note at the beginning: "No unauthorized video or still photography is permitted during the service."

SERVICE PARTICIPANTS

Clergy

Cathedral clergy officiate at all services. Other clergy members are welcome to participate in services. Episcopal clergy canonically resident in other dioceses must seek the consent of the bishop of the Episcopal Diocese of Washington to co-officiate. Regardless of affiliation, all clergy performing weddings in the Cathedral must be licensed to perform weddings by the District of Columbia.

Readers, Prayer Leaders, and Communion Ministers

The service offers opportunities for persons to participate as readers of the lessons and psalm, and leader of the prayers. If Holy Communion is being offered, persons approved by the worship department may serve as chalice bearers.

Ushers

The couple is welcome to designate ushers to assist with distributing orders of service and seating guests.

Junior Participants

All service participants must be at least five years of age and able to join the procession without adult accompanient.

Wedding Planners

The Cathedral's special services manager will coordinate with wedding planners to provide smooth transitions from and to events before and after the wedding rehearsal and service. The worship department alone is responsible for all arrangements concerning the liturgy, seating, movement and placing of participants, commencement of the service, lighting, amplified sound, and flowers.

Rehearsal

An hour-long rehearsal is scheduled in the selected wedding location the Friday before a Saturday wedding. For weddings taking place on other days, the rehearsal will be scheduled at a mutually agreeable time. The rehearsal is conducted under the direction of the officiating clergy and a Cathedral verger. All participants in the ceremony will have the opportunity to walk through the ceremony, ask questions, and work out any logistical details.

All members of the wedding party, including readers, attendants, and clergy, are required to attend the rehearsal and should be present at the Cathedral at least 15 minutes prior to the time of the rehearsal. The wedding couple is responsible for inviting all required parties to the reheasral. We are unable to extend rehearsals to accomodate late arrivals.

The marriage license must be given to the verger prior to the start of the wedding rehearsal. The rehearsal does not take place without the license.

Photography and Videography

Unauthorized photography or videography is not permitted during the service. All photographers and videographers must be briefed on standards and locations by a Cathedral verger ahead of the wedding. The photographer and videographer arrive at the Cathedral one hour prior to the ceremony, and report to the verger upon arrival. Authorization for the locations of video and still photography is at the sole discretion of the verger.

Professional photographers and videographers must conform to the following standards and procedures of the Cathedral.

Flash photography is permitted only in the following instances:

- During the arrival of guests, ushers, and wedding party gatherings prior to the service.
- During the entrance and retiring processions of the bride and groom. The photographer must not enter the aisle, nor in any way come between the members of the procession and the congregation or clergy.
- During any posed photographs after the service, within a fifteen-minute timespan arranged with the verger.
- During the departure of guests.

Flash photography is not permitted in the space during the service.

Only natural/ambient light photography is permitted during service and only from locations designated in advance by a Cathedral verger.

All videography takes place from a stationary location assigned by the verger. No camera movement or additional lighting is permitted.

And over all these virtues put on love,
which binds them all together in perfect unity.

— COLOSSIANS 3:14



FEES

Because the Cathedral must be maintained throughout the year, there are fees associated with the use of the buildings, grounds, and appointments, and for the professional services surrounding a wedding. No portion of the Cathedral charges or flower charges may be considered a charitable contribution for tax purposes. Future gifts to the Cathedral made as acts of thanksgiving for your wedding are most gratefully received and may be fully tax deductible. To inquire about the current schedule of fees, please contact Espy Crisostomo at ecrisostomo@cathedral.org.

SPECIAL NOTE REGARDING BUILDING MAINTENANCE

A building of the Cathedral's size and importance requires thoughtful renovation, repair, and improvement. As a result, scaffolding and construction and other equipment may be staged inside or outside of the building. Because this upkeep is an ongoing process, it is possible that weddings will be scheduled at a time when repairs are being done. While the Cathedral strives to alert couples of all scheduled work, we cannot always predict the location of scaffolding or other equipment many months in advance or when repairs become necessary on an emergency basis.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Is an interfaith ceremony possible?

Yes. We have been blessed to host many beautiful interfaith ceremonies. Clergy from other denominations and faith traditions are invited to participate in the service. All must provide information confirming they are licensed to perform marriages in the District of Columbia and in good standing with the ecclesiastical authority of their tradition. All visiting ministers will work with the Cathedral clergy and an Episcopal priest must preside at the exchange of vows, pronounce the blessing, and sign the marriage license.

Where do we obtain the Declaration of Intent?

All couples intending to marry at the Cathedral must sign and submit the Declaration of Intention. The document may be obtained at **https://edow.org/congregational-resources/worship/marriage/**. This signed document must be submitted to the Cathedral no later than two weeks before the wedding. This form must be signed in the presence of the couple's officiating or consulting clergy.

Where do we obtain our marriage license?

Couples are responsible for obtaining their marriage license. The license must be given to the verger at the rehearsal the day before the ceremony to ensure that all legal obligations are satisfied and so that Cathedral personnel can complete the necessary paperwork before you arrive for the wedding ceremony. After the wedding, the worship office will mail the duly signed license to the appropriate clerk of the District of Columbia.

Information can be found at: **www.dccourts.gov/services/marriage-matters**

Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love.

— EPHESIANS 4:2

Are the Book of Common Prayer and other authorized liturgies easily available?

The Book of Common Prayer is available online at bcponline.org. The other authorized marriage liturgies can be found at www.episcopalcommonprayer.org/existing-liturgies1. The liturgies from A New Zealand Prayer Book, He Karakia Mihinare o Aotearoa can be found at http://anglicanprayerbook.nz/777.html.

May we inlcude non-English language content in the service leaflet?

Service leaflets are produced in English or Spanish. If the couple wishes to include portions of the service in a second language, there may be an additional production or translation fee. All content must be submitted by the three-month deadline and in text form that is compatible with Microsoft Word and Adobe InDesign (no images, including JPG, PNG, etc. formats may be submitted).

How long will the service be?

Most weddings at the Cathedral are between thirty to forty-five minutes. Please note that the inclusion of Holy Communion may extend the length of the service.

Is it possible to host a post-service reception at the Cathedral?

There is limited availability to host post-service receptions inside the Cathedral or on the grounds. Please note that such arrangements are not included in the standard fees. Please contact Espy Crisostomo for more information on the spaces, availability, and fees.

Is parking available?

Yes. Parking for guests is available in the Cathedral parking garage and on surface roads. The Cathedral reserves parking spaces for the wedding party on the day of the wedding only. Should the couple wish to engage the services of shuttles or coaches, arrangements can be made for parking in the Cathedral bus garage.

Is military dress permitted?

Yes. Military dress may be worn by any of the wedding party or a ceremonial guard. No weapons may be worn or displayed within the Cathedral. Covers must be removed within the Cathedral.

Are children welcome?

Yes. Children are always welcome at worship services at the Cathedral, and weddings are no exception. All service participants must be at least five years of age and able to join the procession without adult accompanient.

Can we throw flower petals or rice?

No. Rice, birdseed, confetti, flower petals, and other objects are not to be strewn or blown anywhere inside or outside the Cathedral at any time. Such materials may stain floors and other surfaces and present a slipping hazard.

What about animals?

The release of doves, butterflies, and other animals is not permitted. Dogs and other animals are not allowed to participate in wedding ceremonies at the Cathedral. We warmly welcome service animals as guests.

Can we have an aisle runner?

No. These are not permitted as they permit a hazard to the bridal party and guests.

Is there an honorarium for clergy?

Yes. It is customary that the clergy receives an honorarium from the couple for services performed. For the sake of convenience to both couple and clergy, this honorarium is included in the package fee. Please discuss fees relating to pre-marital counseling directly with the officiant.

CONTACTS

The Reverend Canon Rosemarie Logan Duncan
Canon for Worship
rduncan@cathedral.org

Dr. Torrence N. Thomas
Head Cathedral Verger
tthomas@cathedral.org

Espy Crisostomo
Special Services Manager
ecrisostomo@cathedral.org

Flower Guild
flowers@cathedral.org

Music Deparment
musicoffice@cathedral.org

Worship Deparment
worshipoffice@cathedral.org

APPENDIX

Celebration & Blessing of a Marriage

Procession (with attendants)
Declaration of Consent
Presentation/"giving away"
The Ministry of the Word
The Homily
The Marriage (Vows and Blessing and Exchange of the Rings)
The Prayers
Blessing of the Marriage
The Peace (optional)
Eucharist (if desired)

Blessing of a Civil Marriage

Procession (with attendants)
The Ministry of the Word
The Homily
The Commitment
Blessing of the Rings (optional)
The Prayers
Blessing of the Marriage
The Peace (optional)
Eucharist (if desired)

Love is patient, love is kind.
It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud.
It does not dishonor others, it is not self-seeking,
it is not easily angered, it keeps no record of wrongs.

— 1 CORINTHIANS 13:4-5

WASHINGTON
NATIONAL
CATHEDRAL

3101 WISCONSIN AVENUE, NW • WASHINGTON, DC 20016 • 202-537-6200 • CATHEDRAL.ORG

REVISED JULY 2025